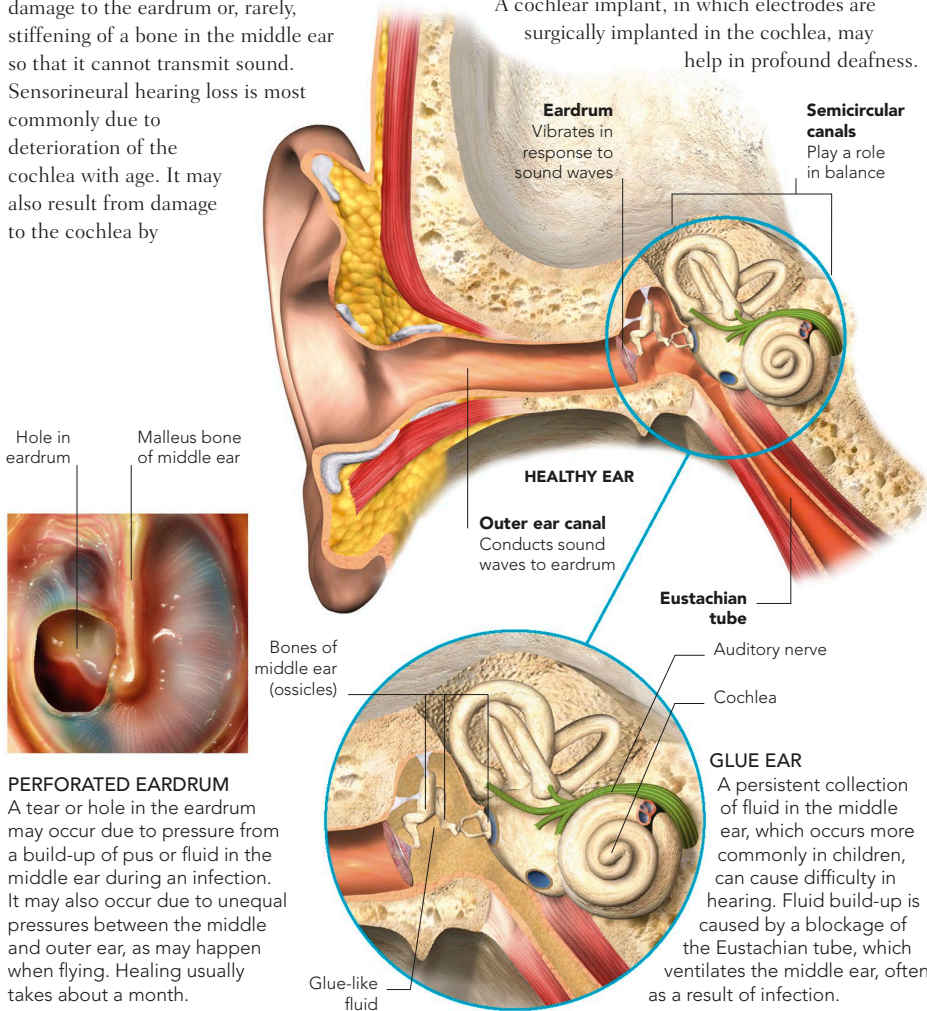


DEAFNESS

There are two types of hearing loss: conductive and sensorineural. Conductive hearing loss results from impaired transmission of sound waves to the inner ear, and is often temporary. In children, the most common cause is glue ear (see below). In adults, it is most commonly due to blockage by earwax. Other causes include damage to the eardrum or, rarely, stiffening of a bone in the middle ear so that it cannot transmit sound. Sensorineural hearing loss is most commonly due to deterioration of the cochlea with age. It may also result from damage to the cochlea by

excessive noise or by Ménière's disease. Rarely, hearing loss is caused by an acoustic neuroma or by certain drugs. Simple measures can be effective for treating conductive deafness, such as syringing the ear to remove earwax. Surgery may be required for glue ear or otosclerosis. Sensorineural deafness usually cannot be cured, but hearing aids can help.

A cochlear implant, in which electrodes are surgically implanted in the cochlea, may help in profound deafness.



PERFORATED EARDRUM

A tear or hole in the eardrum may occur due to pressure from a build-up of pus or fluid in the middle ear during an infection. It may also occur due to unequal pressures between the middle and outer ear, as may happen when flying. Healing usually takes about a month.

GLUE EAR

A persistent collection of fluid in the middle ear, which occurs more commonly in children, can cause difficulty in hearing. Fluid build-up is caused by a blockage of the Eustachian tube, which ventilates the middle ear, often as a result of infection.